

Percutaneous Tibial Nerve Stimulation (PTNS)

WARWIKI

Patient Information · Gentle nerve stimulation at the ankle for overactive bladder

Tibial nerve stimulation (PTNS) is an office treatment for an **overactive bladder**: sudden urges, frequent trips and urge leaks. It uses no medicine. A very thin needle near the ankle sends mild electrical pulses to the **tibial nerve**. This nerve connects to the same nerves that control the bladder. Over a series of visits, this calms the bladder signals.

How It Works

The tibial nerve runs near the inner ankle. It links up to the spinal nerves that run the bladder. Gently stimulating it helps **calm** an overactive bladder, so you have less urgency and fewer trips. Because there is no medicine, there are no side effects in the rest of the body.

Benefits in Numbers

about
5 in 10

were clearly better
after 12 weekly
sessions

about
2 in 10

felt better with a
fake (sham)
treatment, for
comparison

up to
3 years

the benefit lasted
in people who kept
up regular
sessions

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own results may differ; ask your team.

Is It Right for Me?

- An option if lifestyle changes are not enough, or if bladder pills caused side effects or you prefer to avoid them.
- You need to **commit to regular visits**, first to make it work and then to keep it working.
- **Tell your team first** if you have a pacemaker or heart defibrillator, a heart condition, a bleeding problem, nerve damage in the leg, or skin problems at the ankle, or if you are pregnant or plan to be.

Learn the Terms

Overactive bladder

Urgency and frequent urination from the bladder squeezing too soon.

Tibial nerve

A nerve near the ankle that links to the bladder's nerve supply.

Neuromodulation

Using gentle electrical signals to calm overactive nerves.

Percutaneous

Through the skin, using a fine needle.

Sham

A fake treatment used in studies for comparison.

Maintenance

Regular follow-up sessions to keep the benefit.

Will it hurt? Most people feel only mild tingling, a pulsing, or a gentle curling of the toes. It should not be painful. Each session lasts about **30 minutes** while you sit or lie back. You can drive yourself home and go back to your usual activities right away.

Weeks 1–12

One 30-minute session a week.

After session 12

You and your team decide if it is working. Do not judge it sooner.

After that

Maintenance sessions, often about once a month, to keep the benefit.

What Happens

- 1 You sit or lie with your leg supported. A **very thin needle** is placed just above the inner ankle.
- 2 A sticky pad goes on your foot. A small device sends **gentle pulses** for 30 minutes.
- 3 The needle is removed. Nothing is left in your body between visits.

Good to Know

- The benefit builds over the 12 weeks and can fade if you stop.
- Some people use a **skin-pad version at home** (no needle), or a small **implant** in the lower leg that stimulates the same nerve. Ask your team.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Redness, swelling or fluid at the needle site
- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Ankle pain that does not settle after a session
- Bladder symptoms that suddenly get worse

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. PTNS calms an overactive bladder with gentle pulses at the ankle. No medicine is involved.
2. Give it the full 12 weekly sessions before judging it.
3. Plan on regular maintenance sessions to keep the benefit.